

TIOBE Index March 2026

How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

The TIOBE Programming Community Index is updated monthly since 2001. Ratings are calculated from skilled-engineer counts, training courses, and third-party vendors using search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites.

March 2026 Snapshot

#1 Python — 21.25%

#2 C — 11.55% (+2.02%)

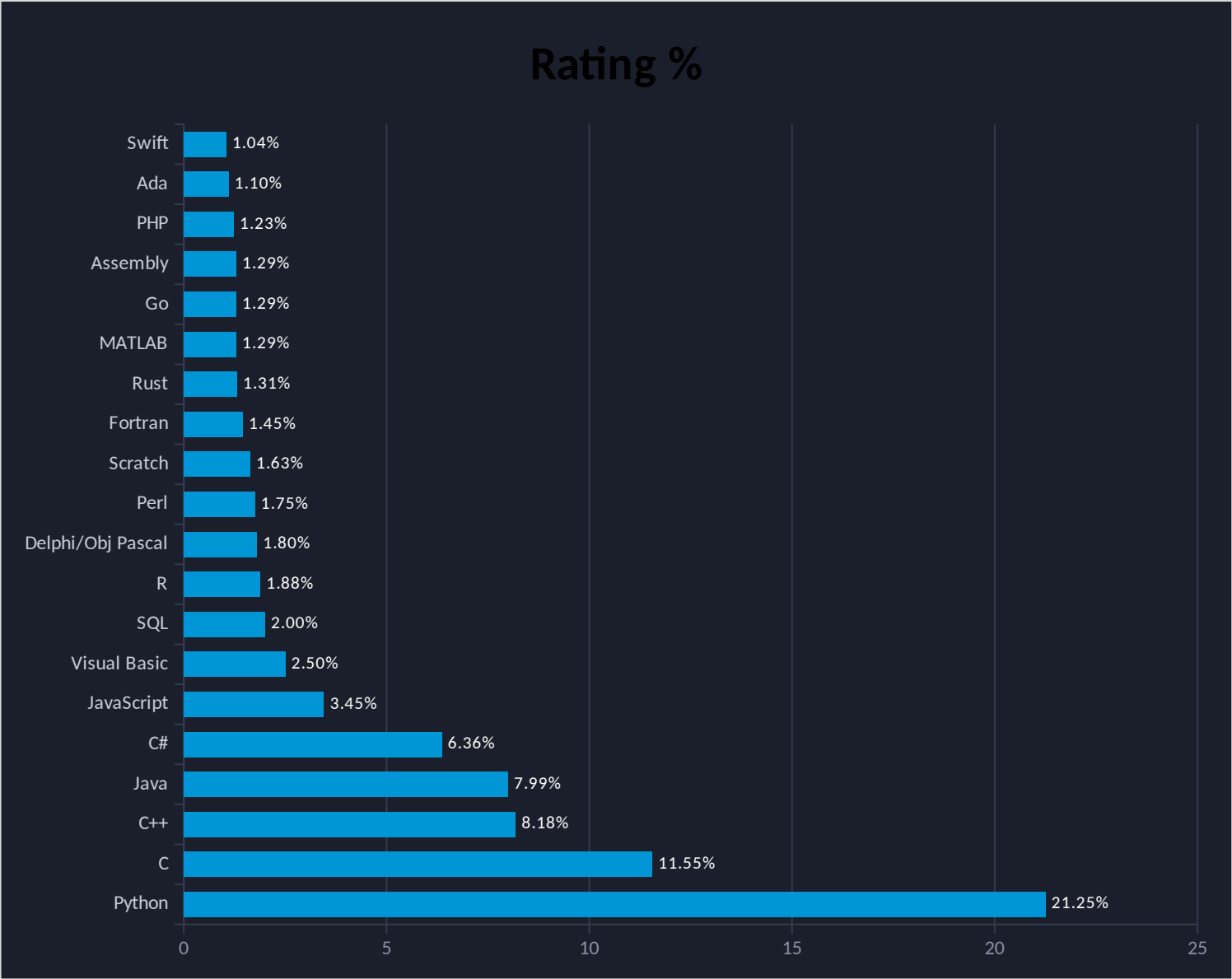
#3 C++ — 8.18%

#4 Java — 7.99%

Top 4 hold 48.97% of index

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Rating %



Year-over-Year Change

# 1 Python	-2.59%
# 2 C	+2.02% ▲2
# 3 C++	-2.90% ▼1
# 4 Java	-2.37% ▼1
# 5 C#	+1.49%
# 6 JavaScript	-0.01%
# 7 Visual Basic	-0.02% ▲2
# 8 SQL	-0.57%
# 9 R	+0.94% ▲7
#10 Delphi/Obj Pascal	-0.36%
#11 Perl	+1.05% ▲13
#12 Scratch	-0.03%
#13 Fortran	-0.25% ▼2
#14 Rust	+0.09% ▲1
#15 MATLAB	+0.31% ▼1
#16 Go	-1.49% ▼9
#17 Assembly	+0.42%
#18 PHP	-0.25% ▼5
#19 Ada	+0.25% ▼1
#20 Swift	+0.44% ▲6

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

▲ GAINERS

Perl 24th → 11th	+1.05%	+13 ranks
R 16th → 9th	+0.94%	+7 ranks
C 4th → 2nd	+2.02%	+2 ranks
Swift 26th → 20th	+0.44%	+6 ranks
C# 5th → 5th	+1.49%	Stable rank

▼ DECLINERS

Go 7th → 16th	-1.49%	-9 ranks
C++ 2nd → 3rd	-2.90%	-1 rank
Java 3rd → 4th	-2.37%	-1 rank
SQL 8th → 8th	-0.57%	Stable rank
Python 1st → 1st	-2.59%	Still #1

Key: Go's -9 rank drop is the largest in the top 20. Legacy languages (Perl, R, Fortran) show surprising resilience in scientific computing and infrastructure.

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	–	–
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	–	–
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	–	–	–
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	–	–
Go	16	11	60	16	–	–	–	–	–
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

- Python: Unranked before 1991 → #26 in 2001 → #1 in 2026. A 25-year climb to dominance.
- C: The only language in the top 2 across all nine measurement points spanning four decades.
- Java: Dominated 2005–2018 at 25%+, now fallen to #4 at under 8%.
- Lisp: #2 in 1986, now #26. Ada: #3 in 1986, now #14. Legacy languages erode slowly.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language

2025 C#	2024 Python ★ Python winner	2023 C#
2022 C++	2021 Python ★ Python winner	2020 Python ★ Python winner
2019 C	2018 Python ★ Python winner	2016 Go

Note: 2017 winner is not available in the source data. Python's 6 total wins: 2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024.

C# won twice recently (2023, 2025), reflecting .NET ecosystem growth. Go's 2016 win contrasts sharply with its current decline from 7th to 16th.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Python: Dominant but Declining

At 21.25%, Python leads by a wide margin — yet its -2.59% YoY drop is the largest among the top 5. Monitor for continued erosion.

C's Resurgence

C surged from 4th to 2nd (+2.02%), proving its staying power in embedded systems, OS kernels, and performance-critical workloads.

Legacy Language Revival

Perl (+13 ranks), R (+7 ranks), and Fortran (still top 15) show entrenched communities in scientific computing and infrastructure are alive and active.

Go's Sharp Fall

Go dropped from 7th to 16th (-1.49%), the largest absolute decline in the top 20. Possible displacement by Rust in systems programming.

Concentration Risk

Python, C, C++, and Java hold 48.97% of the total index. Diversifying language investments reduces risk if any single ecosystem contracts.

Action: Align hiring, training, and tooling investments with these momentum signals. Review your stack against the top 20 quarterly.